EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

If Resurrection Is Allegory, Is the Whole Torah?

Given Wednesday 21 May 2025 · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 7:4-6

Sefer: Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

Essay/Chapters: Essay 7 (The Resurrection of the Dead), Chapters 4, 5 and 6

Shiur: Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 19 May 2025, on Zoom

These notes are based on a transcript of the recording.

Recap: Where the Essay Stands

Three "fairly short chapters and quite quick to go through" tonight.

- **Two resurrections:** one at the end, ushering in Olam HaBa; and one **just for Israel, in this world**.
- **Four avenues of challenge**:
- **Nature** (Chapter 1): it is not a natural impossibility; Hashem can do it.
- **Logic** (Chapter 2): it is not impossible for lack of material. Nor may we explain the resurrection verses as metaphor, because there are **only four times** the Torah may be read non-literally: when it contradicts the senses, contradicts logic (Hashem is not literally **אש אוכלה**, a consuming fire), contradicts another verse, or contradicts tradition (the Torah says forty lashes; the tradition, *halachah leMoshe miSinai*, says 39, so the forty is rounded off).
- **Scripture** (Chapter 3): Saadia explained each verse that seemed to say we go to dust and do not return.
- **Tradition**: next week, Chapter 7.

In Chapters 4, 5 and 6, Saadia brings verses that **positively show** *techiyat hametim*. In the other edition of the essay, the Rabbi noted, Saadia says why: there were many Jews who believed in resurrection at the end of days for Olam HaBa, but not necessarily in a resurrection **in this world**. So his emphasis in Chapter 4 is on showing that it happens in this world.

Chapter 4: Three Prophets

ואחר כן מצאתי כתוב מפורש מה שייעד לו בוראנו: now I bring explicit verses in which our Creator promised it. Three: from Yechezkel, Yeshayahu and Daniel.

1. Yechezkel 37: "I will open your graves"

The people complained, **יבשו עצמותינו ואבדה תקותנו נגזרנו לנו**: our bones are dried up, our hope is lost, we are doomed. Hashem tells Yechezkel to prophesy:

כה אמר ה' אלקים הנה אני פתח את קברותיכם והעליתי אתכם מקברותיכם עמי והבאתי אתכם אל אדמת ישראל. וידעתם כי אני ה' בפתחי את קברותיכם ובהעלותי אתכם מקברותיכם עמי. ונתתי רוחי בכם וחייתם והנחתי אתכם על אדמתכם...

The Rabbi drew out three points:

- **A:** there is a *techiyat hametim*.
- **B: עמי**, "My people": there is a resurrection reserved for Bnei Yisrael.
- **C: על אדמת ישראל**: it happens in this world, "when we have a country called Israel." The resurrection that ushers in the new world is for all the pious, Jews and non-Jews, and in a new world "you don't have Israel there."

Saadia's explanation, phrase by phrase:

- **"Our bones are dried up."** The prophecy opens this way because Hashem knows people will think: how can bones live after drying, how can the moisture return, how can the pure soul be joined again to the body it left? "People lose their loved ones and you think to yourself, how is this person who's in the grave and is drying up in the grave, how will that come back alive again?"
- **"I will bring you up from your graves, My people"**: a promise for Bnei Yisrael alone.
- **"I will bring you to the land of Israel"**: so it takes place in this world, not only at the entrance to Olam HaBa.
- **"And you shall know that I am Hashem when I open your graves"**, which seems repetitive. Saadia: **שכל אחד מהם כשיחיה יתברר לו כי אשר הוא חי הוא אשר מת**, each one, when he lives again, will know that he is the same person who died. The Rishonim asked whether a resurrected person will know he lived before, and Saadia's view is **yes**: "I'm the same person, I lived 100 years ago, a thousand years ago... these were my relatives, this was my wife, this was my husband... you're going to know your family connections."
- **"I will settle you on your land"**: these long days of tranquillity will be on the earth of this world.

2. Yeshayahu 26: "Your dead shall live"

"This is one verse which actually we say at stone settings."

יחיו מתיך נבלתי יקומון הקיצו ורננו שכני עפר כי טל אורת טלך וארץ רפאים תפיל.

Your dead shall live, my corpses shall rise; awake and sing, you who dwell in the dust, for your dew is a dew of lights, and the earth shall cast down the shades. Saadia reads the last phrase as Hashem keeping in the ground those who did not merit resurrection.

Saadia shows that it matches Yechezkel point for point:

- **"Your dead shall live"** parallels "I will open your graves": it is for the Jewish people.
- **"My corpses shall rise"** parallels "I will bring you up from your graves." "It's all matching, it's symmetrical."
- **"Awake"** parallels "you shall know." When you wake from sleep, you know you were dreaming, you remember the dream, and you know you are the same person who slept. So too, "you're going to wake up and you're going to realise, ah, I'm alive. I who lived 1,125 years ago... I am that person."
- **"A dew"** answers "our bones are dried up": you will be moist again.

- **"Of lights"**, in the plural, refers to the soul's faculties, which Saadia set out in the essay on the soul. All of them will come alive again.

"This is an amazing thing. We don't know yet what techiyat hametim in Olam HaBa looks like. But techiyat hametim in this world, which is reserved for Am Yisrael... will be one which the Jewish people will wake up and they will know their lives."

3. Daniel 12: "Many of those who sleep in the dust"

ורבים מישני אדמת עפר יקיצו אלה לחיי עולם ואלה לחרפות לדראון עולם. Many of those who sleep in the dust shall awake, some to everlasting life and some to everlasting shame. Again **יקיצו**," shall awake," with the same meaning: you will know your previous life.

The 47 verses. Then Saadia says "something interesting." How do we know this verse is about resurrection **in this world**? Because it comes at the end of **47 verses** about the exiles, from the start of Daniel 11:

Verses	Kingdom
1	**Persia**, its three kings. Daniel lived at the end of the Persian Empire, so one verse sufficed
13	**Greece**
20	**Rome**
10	**The Arabs**, the Ishmaelites. Saadia lived in the 10th century, as the Arabs spread and conquered
3	**The salvation**, at the start of Daniel 12: "At that time Michael will arise," and "many of those who sleep in the dust shall awake... and shine like the brightness of the firmament"

The Rabbi totted it up with the class: 1, 14, 34, 44, then 45, 46 and 47. And for Saadia, the exile under the Arabs is the **last exile**. Why only three verses for the future? Because Yeshayahu and Yechezkel already explained it.

The point: just as the exiles of Persia, Greece, Rome and the Arabs were all in this world, so too the final three verses, about the end of the exiles and the salvation, must be **in this world**.

Questions on Chapter 4

Q (Richard): Does the presumption of literalism apply to Tanach generally, or only to the Torah? To all of Tanach. Where a prophecy is clear and comprehensible on its face, it is treated as a prophecy, "not a meditation." Is that generally accepted? "Yes, everyone accepts that... Saadia is the starting point and everyone really builds on him," some narrowing it, some widening it.

Midrash is the opposite. The **Maharitz Chayes**, about 200 years ago, said that with Midrash the presumption is that it is **not** literal, unless it makes sense. When the Midrash says Moshe was ten *amot* tall, or that **Batya** stretched out her arm and it grew long, "there are messages behind it." Batya's arm means she put in huge effort: "if you really want to do something in life, you can do it."

The Rabbi's pet hate: "One of the most annoying things, seeing adults reading in synagogue *The Little Midrash Says*." It is lovely for children, who cannot yet grasp the deeper meanings, "but

then they have to come to a point where I understand... it's just a metaphor which has something much deeper inside it."

Chapter 5: If You Allegorise Resurrection

"It seems to be this was something which was bugging him, because he dedicates a whole other chapter" to those who want to make resurrection entirely metaphorical. Leave aside Chapter 2's principles; let us hear their actual arguments.

Their reading

Perhaps the resurrection verses mean the **revival of the kingdom**: Jewish sovereignty coming back to life after it "died." Raising someone from lowliness is like raising him from the dust:

> **מקימי מעפר דל מאשפת ירים אביון להושיבי עם נדיבים** (from Hallel): Hashem raises the poor from the dust. The poor man is not literally sitting in dust.

- The verses compare someone in trouble to the dead: **נשכחתי כמת מלב**, I am forgotten like a dead man.

So the "dead" would be Am Yisrael in its suffering, and "resurrection" would be uplifting them and giving them back sovereignty and power.

Saadia's answer: be consistent

> **אם יתחייב בזה הפרשן**: if the interpreter does this, with no reason forcing him, he will have to do the same with three things: **the mitzvot**, **the ancient narratives**, and **the miracles**, **עד שלא ישאר מהם דבר כפשוטו**, until nothing is left in its plain sense. "Fine, you want to do that? Do that. But if you're going to do that, then be consistent."

1. Mitzvot

"Do not eat chametz" (Parashat Bo). There is no reason to reinterpret it: it contradicts neither the senses, nor logic, nor tradition, nor another verse. But if I like metaphors, it could mean **do not commit adultery**, because Hoshea compares adulterers to leavened dough: **כלם מנאפים כמו תנור... מלוש בצק עד חמצתו**. They stick to one another like sticky dough. So Pesach would carry an extra prohibition of *zenut*.

"Do not kindle fire on Shabbat" (Parashat Vayakhel) could mean **do not wage war on Shabbat**, because war is made with fire, and the Torah calls war with Sichon fire: **כי אש יצאה מחשבון להבה מקרית סיחן**.

"Do not take the mother with the young" (Parashat Ki Tetze) could mean: when you conquer your enemies, **do not kill old and young together**, because Hoshea says of Shalman's destruction of Beit Arbel, **אם על בנים רטשה**, mother was dashed with children, meaning young and old alike.

"You see, you can explain the whole Torah away." When one of the four criteria forces you, do it; when none does, don't.

The Rabbi added that the **Rashba** quotes people living in the time of the Rishonim who explained **tefillin** non-literally: there is no mitzvah to tie anything on, it is about connecting with your heart. "I know this sounds very modern and very 21st century... But then the whole Torah becomes ridiculous."

2. Narratives

Saadia starts at the beginning.

- **"In the beginning God created the heavens and the earth"** could mean He created **a nation from among the nations**. When Israel is in exile it is "**תהו ובהו**," void; and when Hashem restores them, He says **כי הנני בורא שמים חדשים וארץ חדשה**, I create new heavens and a new earth, meaning new times.
- **"Let the earth sprout grass"** could mean **healthy bodies**, since Yeshayahu blesses **ועצמותיכם כדשא תפרחנה**, your bones shall flourish like grass.
- **"Fruit trees bearing fruit"** could mean **a successful king**, from Yechezkel's parable of the cedar planted on the mountain of Israel that **ונשא ענף ועשה פרי**, bears branches and fruit.
- **"Let there be lights"** could mean **Torah, Prophets and Writings**, since **נר מצוה ותורה אור** and **נר לרגלי דברך ואור לנתיבתי**.

"There's nothing left literal... very creative. You can go through many, many more examples like this where everything becomes non-literal, even the whole creation narrative."

3. Miracles

- **The splitting of the Sea. ויבאו בני ישראל בתוך הים ביבשה והמים להם חמה מימינם ומשמאלם**. Perhaps the "water" on their right and left was **Pharaoh's army**, through which they passed safely, and there was no splitting at all, because an army is compared to water: Yeshayahu calls the king of Ashur, Sancheriv, **מי הנהר העצומים והרבים**, the mighty and many waters of the river.
- **The sun standing still** for Yehoshua: **וידם השמש וירח עמד**. Perhaps it means the Israelite **kingdom was firmly established** in the land, since the verses compare the end of a kingdom to the sun setting (**ובאה השמש על הנביאים וקדר עליהם היום**; **באה שמשה בעוד יומם**), and its rise to the sun shining. The Rabbi noted that one of the Rishonim, the **Ralbag**, does interpret the verse in a similar way. "But Saadia is saying a good point, which is all miracles we can really throw out of the window."

The conclusion

Whoever reads the resurrection passages as parables must, to be consistent, read the creation story, all the miracles and all the commandments as parables too. **יצא מכלל תורת ישראל**: if he does that, he has left the Torah of Israel. And if he will not, because he clearly recognises that is wrong, "then why are you doing that with techiyat hametim? You need to be consistent, full stop."

Question: weren't the mitzvot already established?

Richard objected: the mitzvot Saadia uses as examples already had established, transmitted meanings; "don't eat chametz" was always understood as leaven. A new prophecy, at the moment it was given, would not have had an accepted interpretation yet.

The Rabbi understood the question, but answered that Saadia is looking at it "from the perspective of now," a thousand years ago and today, looking back at both the Torah and the prophecies. "Why should we interpret the prophecies of Yechezkel, Yeshayahu and Daniel any different to the verses which say don't eat chametz?" Richard suggested what would matter is how the verses came to be interpreted: if there were early suggestions that they were metaphorical, that would be relevant. "You would have a very valid point if we have evidence that there were competing interpretations from the beginning." Do we? "Not that I know of."

Other questions

Can I know if I've been resurrected? A participant asked how one could tell. The Rabbi explained that she was thinking of **reincarnation**, which Saadia rejects entirely (the class spent a whole chapter on it before Pesach). **Resurrection** has not happened yet; no one has been resurrected. Will it happen? "Every decent human being will" be resurrected.

Must Mashiach come before the year 6000? "It is written. It is written in the Talmud." But the Rambam and others do not take that opinion as authoritative. "I simply don't know. Maybe it will be, maybe it won't be... I don't think anyone can tell you. There are too many opinions."

Chapter 6: The Song of Ha'azinu

"I'm going to fly through this." Saadia found resurrection in **the Shirah of Ha'azinu**, a testimony for Israel throughout the ages. Its arc:

1. **Hashem's kindness**: **הלא הוא אביך קנך הוא עשך ויכוננך**.
2. **The people's rebellion** when life goes well: **וישמן ישרון ויבעט**.
3. **Consequences**: **אסתירה פני מהם**, I will hide My face.
4. **Mercy**: Hashem will punish those who punished us, **לולי כעס אויב אגור**, and have mercy on us through our difficulties.
5. **Redemption.** And then the verse:

ראו עתה כי אני אני הוא ואין אלהים עמדי אני אמית ואחיה מחצתי ואני ארפא ואין מידי מציל.

Four heretics, four answers

Saadia says the verse answers **four kinds of heretics**:

Heretic	Answer in the verse
1. There is no God	**אני אני הוא**: I is it
2. There is a God, but with a partner (two powers, three powers)	**ואין אלהים עמדי**: there is no god with Me
3. Denies *techiyat hametim*	**אני אמית ואחיה**: I put to death and I bring to life
4. Denies Hashem's providence and punishment	**ואין מידי מציל**: none can save from My hand

Why "I put to death and bring to life" means resurrection. Hashem knew some would say it means He makes one generation die and brings another new generation to life, that is, new babies. So the verse adds **מחצתי ואני ארפא**, I strike and I heal. Just as the one healed is **the same one** who was struck, so the one brought to life is **the same one** who was put to death. "And so there we see from that is the concept of techiyat hametim in the Torah itself." The rest of the Shirah goes on to the final salvation.

Summary

1. **Chapter 4, three prophets. Yechezkel 37**: "My people," "to the land of Israel," so a resurrection for Israel in this world; and "you shall know," so the resurrected will remember who they were and recognise their families. **Yeshayahu 26**, said at stone settings, matches it point by point: "awake" as from a dream, "dew" against the dried bones, "lights" for the soul's faculties. **Daniel 12** comes after 47 verses on Persia, Greece, Rome and the Arabs, all in this world, so its resurrection is too.
2. **Tanach is literal by default; Midrash is not** (Maharitz Chayes). Hence Batya's arm, and the Rabbi's plea to grow out of *The Little Midrash Says*.
3. **Chapter 5, consistency.** If resurrection means national revival, then chametz means adultery, Shabbat fire means war, the mother bird means sparing old and young, creation means Israel's restoration, light means Torah, the Sea's walls were Pharaoh's army and the sun's standing was the kingdom's founding. Whoever does that has left the Torah of Israel; whoever won't must read resurrection literally too.
4. **Chapter 6, Ha'azinu.** "I put to death and I bring to life" alongside "I strike and I heal" means the same person who died is revived. The verse answers four heretics.

Coming Up

Next Monday at 6 to 7: **Chapter 7**, the fourth avenue, the **Chachamim**, followed by **Chapters 8 and 9**, the general questions people ask about resurrection, such as "will I see my loved ones?" After finishing the essay there will be a whole shiur on the different views of the Rishonim, the **Rambam** and others, on *techiyat hametim* and how it relates to Mashiach and Olam HaBa.

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/4iMxyHzuGeg · More shiurim: rabbikada.com